

Chapter 83-1

Xu Qingzhu was in the middle of working overtime when she received a call from the mall's delivery personnel, saying they were there to deliver furniture but were stuck downstairs and couldn't get up, asking if she was home.

She was confused for a few seconds before realizing it must be the furniture Liang Shi had ordered. After confirming the details, she had them wait downstairs for over ten minutes while she hurriedly packed up her things and headed home.

Liang Shi had bought quite a lot of things. Xu Qingzhu didn't know exactly where to put everything, so she just had the delivery people pile everything in the living room.

The already small living room immediately became crowded, barely leaving a passage wide enough for one person to walk through.

In this cramped and crowded space, Xu Qingzhu nestled on the sofa and continued working overtime.

Before she knew it, night had fallen. The lights outside lit up the world in an instant. Traffic flowed endlessly across the riverside bridge, and the lights on both banks made the water ripples shimmer brilliantly, carrying a flowing vitality.

Even in the solemn late autumn, it made one feel alive.

Xu Qingzhu opened the window to let in some air, and while she was at it, stood by the window to enjoy the night view for a while before returning to work at her computer.

Before getting back to work, she glanced at her phone—it was already 8:30.

Liang Shi had given her advance notice that there was a farewell dinner tonight and she would probably come back a bit late, reminding her to remember to eat.

But she wasn't very hungry. Once she fully immersed herself in work, she couldn't feel hunger anymore.

Until the rain began to patter outside, and the mist rising in the air shrouded the entire world in the rainy night. Vehicles slowed down, pedestrians on the roadside opened their umbrellas, and those without umbrellas ran frantically through the rain.

The rain grew heavier.

It was already past nine, far exceeding the time Liang Shi usually came home.

Even for a dinner gathering, it should have ended by now.

Xu Qingzhu twirled the phone in her hand a few times, her body leaning lazily and casually against the window. Fine, dense rain threads blew in at an angle with the wind. The thin cardigan on her body was blown up, and although she pinched the two ends of the cardigan together with one hand, a small patch of milky white skin above her collarbone was still exposed, tinged with coolness from the wind and carrying a faint flush of red.

After thinking for a moment, she still called Liang Shi.

If she came back any later, this furniture would have to spend the night in the living room.

What she heard was Liang Shi's voice tinged with drunkenness: "Who's this?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Chapter 83-2

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Xu Qingzhu asked for the location of their gathering, grabbed an umbrella from the entryway, and went downstairs.

It was a twenty-minute drive from the residential complex to there.

By the time she arrived, the restaurant was mostly empty. Only three or four of the colleagues who had been dining with Liang Shi remained, all of them drunk and dizzy.

Zhou Li, who had a child with her, hadn't drunk much, so she was in charge of calling designated drivers for these drunk colleagues.

But because of the rain, designated drivers weren't easy to book.

After being busy for quite a while, they finally managed to send all those colleagues off.

Liang Shi was sitting at the dining table, her body lazily leaning against the chair, holding a half-empty beer bottle in her arms. Her face was flushed red, as if covered with a thick layer of rouge.

The little one couldn't stay up that late. Rainbow had long been extremely sleepy and had already taken a nap curled up in a chair nearby. Now she was drowsy-eyed, but upon seeing Xu Qingzhu, she still called out in a milky voice: "Sister Xu."

Xu Qingzhu gently pinched her face. "Sleep when we get home."

Rainbow stood up and rubbed her eyes, trying to drive away the sleepiness, but the moment her short little legs jumped down from the chair, her knees buckled and she almost fell.

Xu Qingzhu's quick hands caught her.

Rainbow was in the middle of a yawn, her grape-purple eyes brimming with tears, looking adorably silly.

It was only at times like this that one would feel she was just like other children.

She pouted aggrievedly, let out a soft whine, and mumbled: "So sleepy."

Zhou Li immediately picked her up. "We're going home right away, baby. Can you sleep in the car?"

Rainbow buried her head in Zhou Li's neck and responded softly: "Okay."

Zhou Li looked slender, but she could effortlessly carry Rainbow, who weighed several dozen jin¹, while maintaining even breathing as she spoke with Xu Qingzhu. "Then please take Xiao Liang back. I'm really sorry about tonight. This was supposed to be a farewell party for Xiao Liang, but everyone got carried away and got her drunk. Thank you for coming to pick her up."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu smiled faintly. "Take Rainbow home. I'll walk you out."

"No need." Zhou Li declined.

But Xu Qingzhu had already opened the door, smiling: "Let's go."

Zhou Li carried Rainbow, walking steadily the whole way, while Xu Qingzhu held the umbrella for them.

Fine, dense rain threads drifted at an angle under the umbrella. Rainbow nestled in Zhou Li's arms and mumbled: "It's raining."

"Yes." Zhou Li answered gently.

Xu Qingzhu opened the back seat door, and Zhou Li placed Rainbow on the car seat. Rainbow still fought off her sleepiness to say goodbye to Xu Qingzhu: "Bye-bye, Sister Xu."

"Goodbye." Xu Qingzhu closed the car door, and Zhou Li thanked her again.

By the time she saw Zhou Li off, Xu Qingzhu's back was already wet from the rain.

To keep the little one from getting rained on, the umbrella's edge had been tilted toward herself the whole time.

Scattered raindrops pattered onto her back, falling unexpectedly, soaking her clothes and making them stick to her body uncomfortably.

But Xu Qingzhu hadn't thought that much about it at the time. She tugged at the fabric at her shoulders to loosen the shirt underneath, which made her feel slightly better.

She hurried back to the restaurant. A few staff members were whispering among themselves, and some had taken out their phones to sneak photos.

Who knows if they captured anything—anyway, when they saw Xu Qingzhu come in, they hastily put away their phones.

The target who had almost been secretly photographed was lazily nestled in a chair, the corners of her lips curved in just the right arc, those beautiful eyes crinkled in a smile, hugging the beer bottle and refusing to let go.

Xu Qingzhu walked over and patted her shoulder. Her cool, clear voice was tinged with the bite of the autumn wind outside: "Liang Shi, time to go."

Liang Shi frowned and looked up at her, but squinted because the light stung her eyes. "You....."

Her voice after drinking too much was somewhat muffled and hoarse. After saying just one word, her throat felt uncomfortable, and her brow furrowed even tighter.

Her brown hair had completely fallen loose. She was wearing only a light blue shirt, with one button at the collar undone, revealing her delicate collarbone that connected to her beautiful jawline. The skin in that area was tinged with a tender pink.

They had eaten spicy food for dinner, so even her lip color was a deep red, with traces of alcohol still remaining on her lips, shimmering under the light.

Xu Qingzhu extended two fingers and pinched her neck. Liang Shi let out a soft whimper, shrank her neck, and smiled charmingly: "Don't....."

Xu Qingzhu bent down, and the long hair tucked behind her ear fell forward. "Liang Shi, give me the bottle."

The tips of her hair, carrying a fresh orange scent, happened to brush past Liang Shi's nose. She sniffed lightly, her voice lowered, and smiled dazedly: "Your hair smells just like my wife's."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She really was drunk.

Xu Qingzhu didn't bother arguing with a drunk. She went to take the beer bottle from Liang Shi's arms, but Liang Shi desperately protected it, even moving the bottle in the other direction to avoid her reach.

The remaining half bottle of liquid sloshed and swayed in the bottle, and a few drops splashed directly onto Xu Qingzhu.

The most noticeable was the drop on her neck, teetering on the edge of falling.

The icy sensation made Xu Qingzhu uncomfortable. She was about to raise her hand to wipe it off when Liang Shi said in a low voice: "Don't move."

That voice carried the hoarseness of intoxication, making one's heart itch.

Liang Shi slowly raised her neck, approaching Xu Qingzhu's neck. Her scorching breath spilled entirely onto Xu Qingzhu's skin, burning her until her whole body stiffened.

Xu Qingzhu didn't know what she was going to do.

The next second, that warm tongue tip lightly traced across the skin of her neck, nimbly and deftly licking away that drop of alcohol, leaving behind a patch of moisture.

Liang Shi swallowed the liquid, then raised her hand, her fingertip gently wiping over that moist patch from before.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu with a dazed smile and said softly: "Smells so good."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She was lost for a moment.

A moment later, Xu Qingzhu regained her senses and pinched Liang Shi's waist. The pain made Liang Shi frown: "It hurts....."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her sideways. "Come home with me."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, lowered her eyes, her tone dropping, sounding unhappy:
"Oh."

Xu Qingzhu thought she was actually going to obediently put down the beer bottle, but instead she hugged it and started gulping it down.

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Liang Shi's light brown pupils made her look like a cunning little fox.

She said: "Just let me finish this little bit."

Footnotes:

¹ **Jin (斤)**: A traditional Chinese unit of weight. One jin equals 500 grams or approximately 1.1 pounds. "Several dozen jin" would mean roughly 20-40+ pounds (10-20+ kg), which is a typical weight for a young child.

Chapter 83-3

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Getting Liang Shi out of the restaurant took Xu Qingzhu an immense amount of effort. After coming out and seeing that it was raining, Liang Shi actually took the initiative to hold the umbrella for Xu Qingzhu.

But she was drunk, so even holding an umbrella was all crooked. When Xu Qingzhu wouldn't let her hold it, she got upset.

The result of all that fooling around was that both of their clothes got wet. After getting back in the car, when Xu Qingzhu was helping Liang Shi fasten her seatbelt, Liang Shi's nose twitched and she let out a huge sneeze.

.....

After Xu Qingzhu climbed off her lap, she smoothed back her hair and looked at her through gritted teeth. "If you get drunk again, I'll leave you on the street."

"The street?" Liang Shi frowned. "But it's raining outside."

"Then I'll let you get rained on." Xu Qingzhu fastened her own seatbelt and turned on the car's heater, saying coldly: "Getting rained on more will sober you up."

Liang Shi rested her head against the car window and slowly shook her head: "Don't want that."

Xu Qingzhu snorted lightly. "It's not up to you."

"You're so fierce." Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu. "Are you still my wife?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu threatened viciously: "If you get drunk again, I won't be."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together.

After a moment of silence, Liang Shi gazed at the intertwining, lingering lines of rain outside the window, her voice low and muffled: "You're not my wife."

Xu Qingzhu: "???"

"My wife is very gentle." Liang Shi said. "She's very beautiful, and lots of people like her. Her personality is especially good, and she's very capable. She's so charming when she works. It's just....."

She paused. "Every time her hair falls down, I really want to tie it up for her, but... I can't seem to get close."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"Why can't you?" When Xu Qingzhu asked, her voice lifted at the end, clearly pleased.

Liang Shi shook her head: "I just can't."

"She doesn't have thorns." Xu Qingzhu said. "If you tie her hair for her, would she prick you?"

"No~" Liang Shi closed her eyes briefly. Her light-colored pupils appeared iridescent in the constantly changing colors of the lights. "But I just can't."

"Why can't you?" Xu Qingzhu asked again.

"I just can't." Liang Shi said. "Why so many 'whys'?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She must be crazy, desperately trying to reason with a drunk.

What could possibly come from reasoning with her?

Xu Qingzhu completely shut up. Liang Shi also leaned against the car window with her eyes closed, entering a light sleep.

The streets of Haizhou City at night were bustling with traffic. The car merged into the sea of vehicles, heading toward its destination, and the inside of the car quieted down.

Xu Qingzhu played some soothing light music. Liang Shi, who had already entered a light sleep, had her fingers actually tapping along to the rhythm.

Her slender, pale fingers tapped lightly on her leg, as if playing an invisible piano.

The rain was heavier on this side along the river. By the time they got home, it was already ten o'clock.

Probably because she had slept a bit on the way, Liang Shi had sobered up somewhat and could already follow behind Xu Qingzhu into the elevator.

But she still seemed drowsy overall, without much energy.

The living room was piled full of all kinds of new furniture—it was hard to even find a place to step.

Liang Shi stood dazed at the entryway for a few seconds, frowning as she asked Xu Qingzhu: "Why did it become like this?"

"You bought it." Xu Qingzhu hung her wet coat at the entryway. "You're asking me?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I bought it?" Liang Shi was confused, then after thinking carefully, said in a low voice: "Seems like I did buy it."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Right now, she just wanted this drunk to go to sleep.

The light in the living room was dim and yellow. After Liang Shi took off her shoes, she bent down to arrange them neatly, then moved to take off Xu Qingzhu's high heels.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her in surprise. "What are you doing?"

"Arranging shoes." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I don't need you to." Xu Qingzhu pushed her shoulder—she clearly used very little force, but Liang Shi ended up sitting on the floor mat, then looked up at Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu's feelings were complicated, but she still extended her hand toward her, wanting to pull her up.

But Liang Shi shook her head and said firmly: "I want to arrange the shoes."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She couldn't win against this drunk, so she could only stand there steadily and let her do as she pleased.

Even though they had just come back from outside, the cold wind hadn't made Liang Shi's hands cold.

Her warm hands landed on Xu Qingzhu's ankle, then gently lifted her leg while her other hand removed the high heel.

Xu Qingzhu's instep was very pretty, glowing white even under the dim yellow light.

Liang Shi suddenly bent down and placed a kiss on her instep.

Xu Qingzhu stood at the entryway, her hand propped against the wall cabinet. The marble-topped shelf made her palm cold, which restored some of her rationality.

But she was suddenly startled by Liang Shi's unexpected kiss.

The warm sensation made Xu Qingzhu's tailbone go numb directly, her whole body going weak, almost collapsing.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lower lip, her hand gripping the wall cabinet tightly, not daring to move her feet at all, afraid of hurting Liang Shi.

"What are you doing?" Xu Qingzhu asked coldly.

Liang Shi looked up at her, her eyes holding a smile, her voice an alluring rasp: "Wifey~"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"You're drunk." Xu Qingzhu was somewhat flustered when she spoke, her eyes not daring to meet Liang Shi's. "Go to bed quickly."

But Liang Shi lifted her other foot, removed the high heel, and in the same manner, unexpectedly kissed her fair instep.

"What are you doing?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

In that instant, her tailbone was going numb, and all her body's strength was leaning against the wall cabinet.

"Can't favor one over the other." Liang Shi lowered her head to wipe away the trace on her instep, gently stroking it, her voice carrying a faint smile. "Must treat them equally."

"....."

So this is how "favoring one over the other" and "treating equally" are used!

Xu Qingzhu leaned her back against the wall cabinet and kicked Liang Shi lightly. "Get up. Go to bed."

"What about you?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu: "I'm going to bed too."

Liang Shi: "Not together?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Chapter 83-4

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Xu Qingzhu stood in the kitchen making honey water for Liang Shi. The stirring stick swirled back and forth in the cup, turning the clear water a different color.

The sensation from just now kept coming to mind at inopportune moments, making her not even know which foot to step with first when walking.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the cold wall, forcing herself to regain her composure.

She finally felt a bit better.

She went to bring the honey water to Liang Shi, forcibly pulling her out from where she was nestled in bed and making her drink the entire cup.

Then she went to the kitchen to wash the cup and stood by the window to get some air.

She felt like her whole self was going to explode tonight.

The impact from just now was simply too great. If Liang Shi had continued, she seemed like she would have had no power to resist.

Was that perhaps her sensitive spot?

Or was it the moment when Liang Shi looked up and smiled at her after the kiss—it was like a shot fired straight at her heart.

A direct hit.

Her two legs were weak and sore, as if she had just gone through a maddening session of intimacy.

But in reality, it was just a kiss.

The kind of kiss often seen in TV drama scenes.

But when it actually happened, Xu Qingzhu almost couldn't handle it.

In that instant, she had the urge to kiss Liang Shi.

But she still held back.

Kissing someone while they're drunk wasn't very ethical.

The wind tousled Xu Qingzhu's hair. The night view here was much more beautiful than at Shallow Water Bay. Just looking at the endlessly flowing water ripples illuminated by lights and the endless stream of vehicles on the road, one could stand here watching all night.

Xu Qingzhu's head bumped against the glass. The cold glass gave her forehead a moment of coolness.

Using this to cool down the jumbled mess in her mind.

Just as her head lightly bumped against the glass, a hand landed on the glass, and her forehead fell right into that warm hand.

Xu Qingzhu was startled. She turned around to find Liang Shi standing behind her.

She had been standing lazily to begin with, her whole body somewhat tilted. When she turned around, her head unexpectedly buried itself in Liang Shi's chest.

.....It was actually quite soft.

Xu Qingzhu's first impression made her hesitate for a moment, while Liang Shi asked gently: "Comfortable?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She immediately pulled away, but the movement was too big and she almost bumped into the window again.

Liang Shi pulled her back, but ended up pulling her right back into her arms.

.....

Xu Qingzhu found herself completely trapped in Liang Shi's embrace. Liang Shi's height was quite imposing in this newly changed apartment. Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up slightly, and her lips brushed past Liang Shi's jaw.

Liang Shi also lowered her head.

Their eyes met.

Xu Qingzhu lightly licked her lips. Those pink lips shimmered with a glistening light. Liang Shi slowly leaned down, but when that kiss was about to land, she placed her own hand in between.

Xu Qingzhu kissed the back of her hand, while her lips landed on her own palm.

Liang Shi's free hand tucked Xu Qingzhu's loose hair behind her ear, then leaned in close to ask softly by Xu Qingzhu's ear: "Can I hug you?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She felt her ears burning, yet she nodded gently.

Liang Shi bent her waist, wrapped her arms around Xu Qingzhu's waist, and gathered her entirely into her embrace.

Xu Qingzhu's arms also came to rest on Liang Shi's slender waist.

Liang Shi gazed at the night view outside, her voice still carrying a hint of drunkenness as she asked quietly: "Teacher Xu, want to go see the ocean?"

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

Liang Shi smiled. "I want to go see the ocean."

Xu Qingzhu: "When?"

Liang Shi: "Right now."

Chapter 83-5

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Liang Shi's voice at that moment was so pleasant that Xu Qingzhu simply followed her decision without even thinking about how going to see the ocean late at night was a very foolish idea.

And Liang Shi, who was no longer that drunk after drinking a cup of honey water, pulled Xu Qingzhu out of the house after proposing to see the ocean.

Xu Qingzhu drove toward the seaside on the outskirts of the city. Liang Shi sat in the car bobbing her head along to the music.

Haizhou City was a coastal city with an entire coastline. It became a popular tourist destination at the turn of spring and summer, so seeing the ocean late at night wasn't difficult to achieve.

It was just a bit... foolish.

When the car stopped by the roadside, and the moment they got out they could hear the sound of waves, and the air was filled with the salty, briny smell of the sea, and the wind was so cold that if you weren't careful it would burrow into your clothes, invade your body, and make you shiver—Xu Qingzhu felt that she might be an idiot, a lunatic.

A lunatic who came along to be crazy with Liang Shi.

But Liang Shi didn't feel cold at all. She even took off the black wool coat she was wearing, leaving only a light blue shirt. Her long hair danced wildly in the wind. She ran onto the beach, took off her shoes, and stood at the water's edge, facing the ocean.

The beach that was bustling during the day was now completely empty. The searchlights in the distance shone brightly, and Liang Shi's shadow fell on the beach.

Watching her, Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but feel she looked so lonely.

She stood there as if she didn't belong in this world.

After pausing for a few seconds, Xu Qingzhu cupped her hands around her mouth and shouted loudly: "Liang Shi!"

Liang Shi turned around. The wind had blown her hair over her eyes. She used one hand to brush it aside, and when she looked at Xu Qingzhu, she revealed a faint smile. "Hm?"

Her thin voice was swallowed by the waves. Wave after wave rolled in with the wind, bringing along a pile of marine creatures, wetting Liang Shi's feet. When the tide was strong, the seawater even covered her ankles.

Xu Qingzhu didn't hear her reply, but she still walked all the way to her side and stood shoulder to shoulder with her.

Xu Qingzhu asked her: "Why did you suddenly want to see the ocean?"

Liang Shi walked along the beach holding her coat. She asked Xu Qingzhu: "What's your dream?"

Xu Qingzhu was taken aback. She glanced sideways at her. "Are you still drunk right now?"

Liang Shi stopped in her tracks. She smiled and shook her head, very different from her usual self. "I don't know."

Xu Qingzhu understood—half drunk.

Not as crazy as before.

"Do you still remember what happened just now?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi breathed out lightly. "What happened?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Forget it, she gave up.

She would just wait for Liang Shi to review it herself tomorrow after completely sobering up.

Xu Qingzhu redirected the topic back to her earlier question. "Then what's your dream?"

Liang Shi laughed lightly. "You're cheating. I asked you first."

Xu Qingzhu: "Then you answer first."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "So childish."

"You're the childish one." Xu Qingzhu said.

After a while, Liang Shi kicked at some sand. She said: "My dream is to have lots and lots of love. I want everyone to like me."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly stopped. She looked at Liang Shi. "Liang Shi, were you kidnapped when you were little?"

Liang Shi also stopped following her footsteps, turned around and looked at her from not too far away, shaking her head. "I don't know."

"What do you mean?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "I don't have any memories from before I was eight years old."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Be more specific."

"I don't remember what happened before I was eight." Liang Shi said. "I remember Madam Qi, I remember Qi Jiao, but those are all things I recalled in dreams. I don't have any memories from before I was eight. Including my original parents—I don't remember them either. They passed away before I turned eight. I grew up with my grandparents."

Liang Shi suddenly squatted down, and Xu Qingzhu squatted down with her.

This was the first time Xu Qingzhu heard her talk about things from "the other side."

Actually, she had always felt that when Liang Shi said she wasn't the original Liang Shi, it didn't feel real.

Now Xu Qingzhu had already forgotten what the previous Liang Shi was like. She only remembered "very bad," very annoying.

But the current Liang Shi was completely different. If you actually calculated it, it hadn't been that long, but she had already completely adapted to the current Liang Shi.

As if Liang Shi was supposed to be like this.

The one before was just someone else.

Not the jiejie who was kidnapped with her when they were little, nor the person she wanted to marry.

Xu Qingzhu had been busy with her own matters, and since she felt that Liang Shi didn't really want to bring up the past, she had deliberately suppressed her own curiosity.

So she had never asked, and thus had no way of knowing.

A drunk Liang Shi seemed to have a strong desire to share. She took the initiative to mention the past, to mention the family she grew up with.

And this wasn't the first time Xu Qingzhu heard her say: "I want to have lots of love."

Xu Qingzhu had watched that movie and had heard others say that line.

But the same tone, the same falling intonation at the end—only Liang Shi was like this.

When that sentence came from her mouth, it gave Xu Qingzhu an immense sense of familiarity. When anyone else said it, there was none.

Xu Qingzhu had even discussed this with her therapist.

The therapist's advice was to observe slowly. If there were more small details to support it, then that would indicate the two were the same person.

Because Xu Qingzhu's memory of being kidnapped was very vivid, especially regarding the person who saved her, that memory was particularly clear and unlikely to be wrong.

Xu Qingzhu faced her and asked: "What kind of people were your grandparents?"

Liang Shi suddenly smiled, her smile carrying nostalgia and longing. "They were very simple people. They didn't have much money, but every cent they earned, they wanted to spend on me."

"When I was in middle school, I went to the county town to participate in a running competition. Grandma bought me a pair of shoes for five hundred yuan¹." Liang Shi said. "Maybe five hundred is nothing to you all, and to me now, five hundred is nothing either. But back then, five hundred was money my grandma had to save for two months to accumulate."

"And Grandpa—he was very fierce, but he would ride his bicycle to take me to faraway places. He would take me to catch dragonflies and fireflies. He would hold up a world map and tell me that the world is big, and I shouldn't just stay here."

Liang Shi's eyes glistened with tears. She looked at Xu Qingzhu. "So after they passed away, I went to the big city. I became an actress, wanting to make many people like me, because they once told me that I would definitely become a shining person."

Xu Qingzhu raised her hand, her palm resting on Liang Shi's cheek.

Liang Shi's face moved slightly, nuzzling against her palm. "The thing Grandpa and Grandma wanted to do most was to see the ocean, but they never got to see it. So I came to fulfill their dream for them."

Footnotes:

¹ **Five hundred yuan (五百):** At the time referenced (likely 10-15 years ago in a rural area), 500 yuan would be a significant amount of money for a low-income family. For context, this would be roughly equivalent to 70-80 USD, but the purchasing power and relative value would be much higher in rural China. The fact that it took the grandmother two months to save this amount indicates the family's economic circumstances.